norm in Srinagar and some other places in the valley, where the youth resorted to provocative stone-throwing, violence, and slogan shouting. At places the paramilitary forces or the police had to open fire when the mobs got out of control, resulting in the death of ninety-eight civilians over the next few months.

In the rest of J&K, however, the situation is well under control. The ceasefire along the line of control is holding, barring the odd occasion when the Pakistan Army indulges in unprovoked firing, presumably to facilitate infiltration. The number of terrorists operating in J&K has also come down. They hesitate to engage the army and many have surrendered.

Indo-Pak government talks at various levels and confidence-building measures remain the cornerstone for solving the long-standing issue between the two countries. As part of the confidence-building measures, it was decided to enhance people-to-people contact on both sides of the LoC. The most important step in this direction was the start of a bus service from Srinagar to Muzaffarabad. The terrorist organizations and jehadis were vehementally opposed to this idea. Perhaps they did not want the people of J&K to see the underdeveloped state of Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK). I directed HQ Northern Command, and 15 Corps in particular, to meet the deadline to operationalize the historic Srinagar-Muzaffarabad bus link on 7 April 2005. We had to undertake demining operations of the border on our own side and improvement of the road for the final ten kilometers beyond Uri.

The last 300 metres, including a bridge with a span of about 50 metres, had to be made against time. Our military engineers did a marvellous job and we named the bridge as ‘Aman Setu’ (the Bridge of Peace). Many families were reunited after decades because of this road link. We anticipated that the terrorists might try to derail this process and target the buses. In the beginning we took the precaution of aerial as well as ground surveillance to sanitize the route and were prepared to take prompt action in case the terrorists struck the bus. Fortunately, no adverse incident happened, except once when the terrorists carried out some blasts to disrupt the bus service. However, this ill-advised action boomeranged and the